Jinping might offer some basic technical assistance on issues like launch authentication or setting up permissive action links (PAL). Helping train missile technicians in damage control and critical repair of launch systems might add another layer of certainty to the daily maintenance of nuclear weapons. And despite the distaste for accepting Pyongyang as a nuclear power, considering some US–North Korean confidence-building mechanisms, perhaps even midwifed by Beijing, may come to be seen as a necessary evil in the new nuclear world.

VIII.

Of course, the moment that war breaks out on the Korean Peninsula, all these attempts at maintaining North Korean nuclear surety will be blown away, figuratively or literally. When that happens, the US military undoubtedly will immediately attempt to destroy North Korea's command and control network so as to make it difficult if not impossible for Kim to use his nukes. It would also most likely attempt a quick decapitation strike and would target as many of Kim's fixed and mobile nuclear assets as possible, trying to destroy them on the ground.

The outbreak of war along the Demilitarized Zone would of course represent the failure of US security policy on the Korean Peninsula. Yet ironically, if Washington is successful in avoiding war but fails to denuclearize North Korea, then Asia and the world will be condemned to a perpetual, if cold, nuclear peace with Pyongyang. Years of nuclear brinksmanship, bluffing, and threats may also ensue, at least as long as Kim Jong-un and his regime remain in power. In the absence of denuclearization, the supreme task of policy makers will be to prevent North Korea from ever using its nuclear force. That will require new thinking about deterrence and containment, but a major part of that will come down to how well the North Koreans manage their nuclear forces, keeping them safe, reliable, and under control at all times. Like the 1940s naval theorist Bernard Brodie, who wrote upon hearing about the atomic bombing of Hiroshima that everything he'd written was